

IPOD MINI

Talk of MP3 players or portable music players and the first image that springs up is the plain white face of the iPod. The impact of the Pod has been so great that it has become synonymous with portable music players. What was it that made it a cultural phenomenon, a must-have accessory?



We think the intuitive user interface and a radical yet minimalist design might have helped. The fact that it is a hard disk-based player means it can store many more files than conventional portable players. Add to

this the image Apple had built up over the years of being a niche über-cool brand, and you have a winner. Apple also came up with an online music download service, iTunes. At 99 cents or around Rs 42 per download, this was a definite steal. Pity iTunes isn't accessible from India yet.

Available in different capacities, the Pod that has caught our fancy was the iPod Mini. With a 4 GB (or 6 GB) storage capacity, the Mini can hold between 2,000 and 3,000 songs of MP3 quality. The metallic-coloured bodies also add to charm of this baby, which is slightly larger than a credit card.

With street prices starting at Rs 12,000 for the 4 GB variant, this nifty little gizmo is well within the reach of any average buyer. Of course, those with deeper pockets can always go in for the 20 GB iPod or the U2 special-edition ones.

Rs 12,000

IRIVER H 10

They call it the soul machine, one look at the Ferrari red and metallic colour combination and you know why. The minimalist navigation design and the colour TFT LCD screen gets any gadget lover hooked. A visual treat, you say, plug in those ear phones and this gadget sings as well. With a 5GB solid state storage capacity and with features such as FM recording, voice recording, photo and text viewing and multiple language support the H10 is a serious contender for the top spot in its category. The player has the basic equalizer modes and 30 preset ones as well but what is sorely missed was a line in plug, which comes only with a cradle. The H10 series however does not offer support to all the different file types, only the basic MPEG and WMA for audio and JPEG for image. At Rs 16,000 this is priced at a premium when compared to the competitors but for a sub 100gm, pocket sized 5 GB mp3 player we think it just about makes the cut.



Rs 16,000



Rs 15,000

CREATIVE ZEN MICRO & ZEN NEEON

Creative's MuVo2 never quite took the MP3 player market by storm. Many said it was the clunky design that did the MuVo in. Not to be upstaged, Creative has hit back with their international bestsellers—the Zen Micro and the Zen Neon.

With refreshingly new designs coupled with a 5 GB hard disk, these players are out to deliver a one-two knockout punch. The best thing about the players is that you don't have to convert or reconvert your music files into any proprietary format—something both Sony and Apple players demand.

The Neon's 5 GB capacity means that you can store a large chunk of your music collection on the player; of course, you can also store other data files and use the player as a portable drive. The interchangeable covers and

the changing neon backlight add a large dose of pizzaz to the gizmo. So go ahead and co-ordinate your MP3 player with your wardrobe... and feel free to get right back at us if this showstopper doesn't catch everyone's attention!

At a starting price of Rs 15,000, the Zen Neon is directly aimed at the would-be iPod Mini customer. For an MP3 player that sounds great and makes you look cool, it isn't too expensive.